The Rise of Vijayanagar

In the late thirteenth century, south India was a patchwork of small warring kingdoms with shifting borders, many plagued by internecine rivalries for power. The largest of them were the Hoysalas of Karnataka, the Kakatiyas of Andhra and various dynastic claimants of the once powerful Pallavas, the Cholas, the Pandyas and the Cheras of Tamil country and Kerala. This fragmented political geography was jolted by a new and formidable expansionary force in the early fourteenth century: the Delhi Sultanate, led by Ala-ud-Din Khalji, a first-generation Turko-Afghan migrant soldier into north India, and Muhammad bin Tughlak, a Delhi-born grandson of a Turkic slave father and Hindu concubine mother. Their cavalry-led armies were far more professional and ruthless than what the southern rulers were used to.

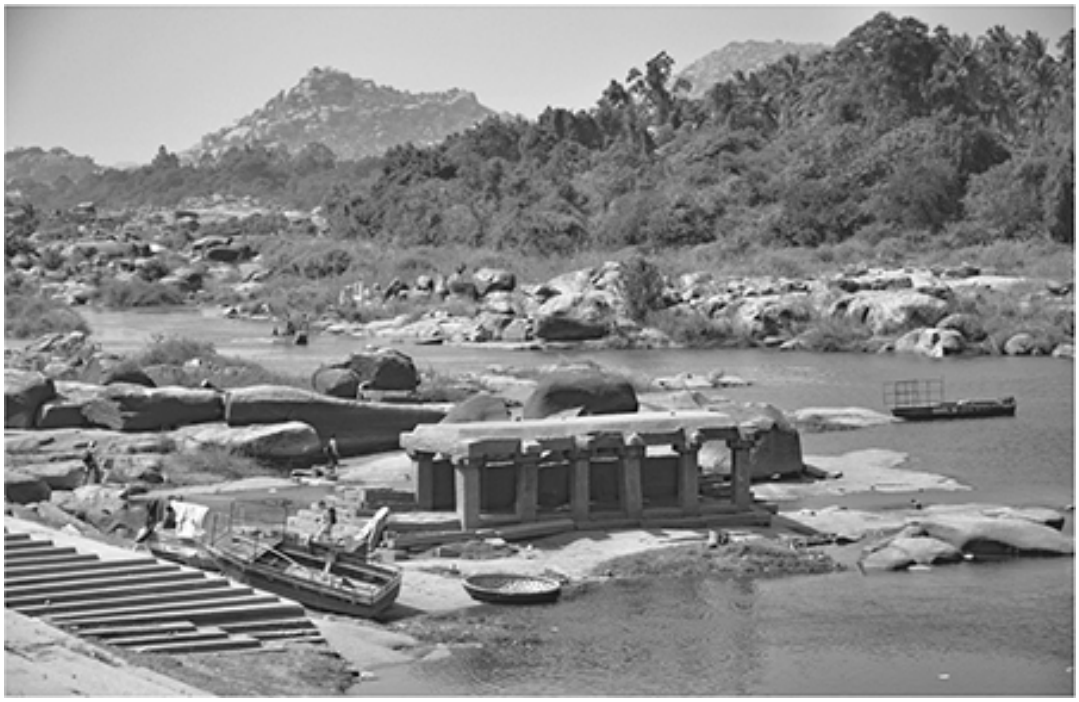


Figure 4. Tungabhadra River

The ensuing decades saw great battles and the rise and fall of many kingdoms. When the dust cleared a bit in the mid-fourteenth century, the